

EVIDENCE • CANVAS • SERIES

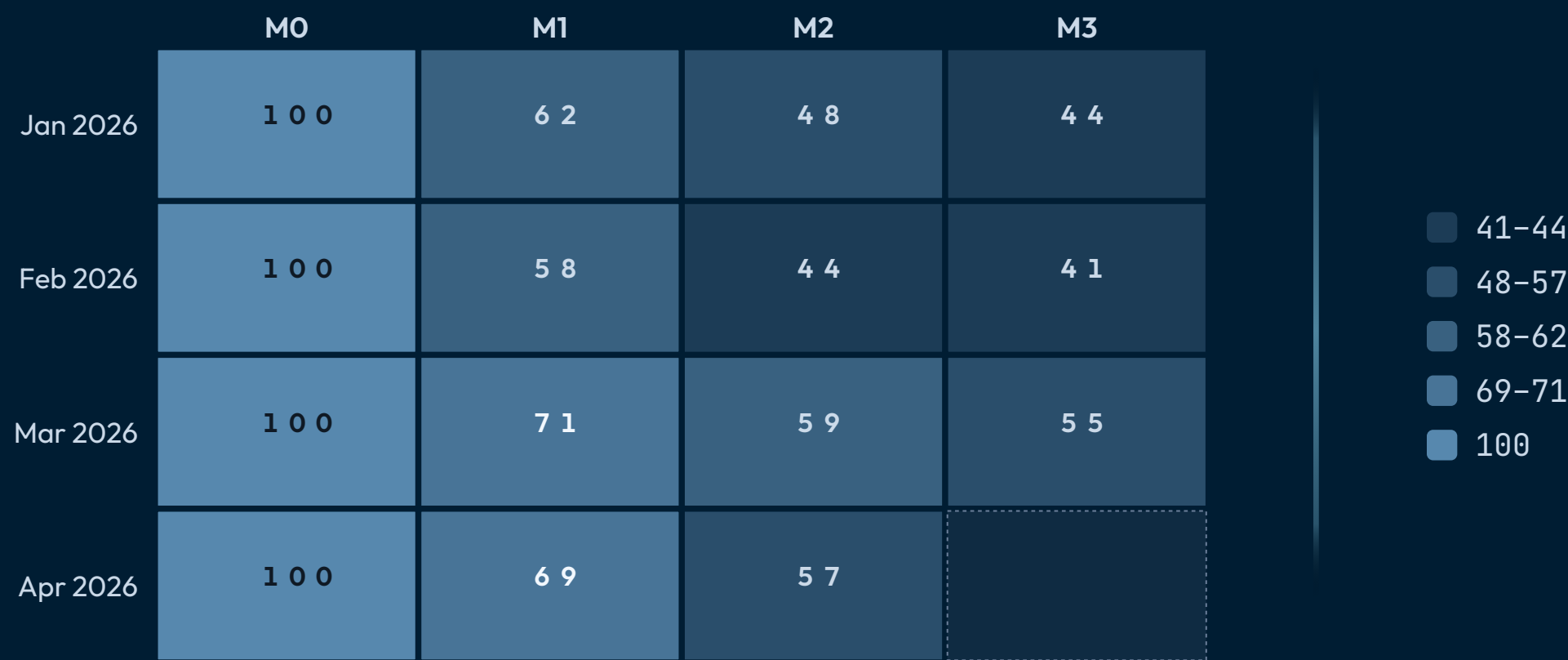
heatmap

A numeric matrix read as intensity — where the value concentrates across two dimensions.

Retention decays fastest in month two.

	M0	M1	M2	M3
Jan 2026	1 0 0	6 2	4 8	4 4
Feb 2026	1 0 0	5 8	4 4	4 1
Mar 2026	1 0 0	7 1	5 9	5 5
Apr 2026	1 0 0	6 9	5 7	

The chart names its own bands.



RETENTION · THE CEILING

Ten cohorts by twelve months — the density this holds.

	M0	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9	M10	M11
January 2026...	1 0 0 7 1	5 9	5 5	5 2	5 0	4 8	4 7	4 6	4 5	4 4	4 3	
February 2026	1 0 0 5 8	4 4	4 1	3 9	3 8	3 7	3 6	3 5	3 4	3 3	3 2	
March 2026	1 0 0 6 2	4 8	4 5	4 3	4 2	4 1	4 0	3 9	3 8	3 7		
April 2026	1 0 0 6 9	5 7	5 4	5 1	4 9	4 8	4 7	4 6	4 5			
May 2026	1 0 0 6 6	5 4	5 0	4 8	4 7	4 6	4 5	4 4				
June 2026	1 0 0 6 4	5 2	4 9	4 7	4 6	4 5	4 4					
July 2026	1 0 0 6 1	5 0	4 7	4 5	4 4	4 3						
August 2026	1 0 0 5 9	4 8	4 5	4 3	4 2							
September 2026	1 0 0 5 7	4 7	4 4	4 2								
October 2026	5 5	5 5	5 5	5 5								

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RETENTION · 2026 COHORTS

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When NOT to reach for heatmap.

One row of numbers

A single series is not a matrix — it is a comparison, and a reader judges length far more precisely than intensity. Use `bar`. The kernel declines a one-column table for this reason rather than painting a single strip.

Qualitative cells

If the cells are verbs, owners or statuses rather than numbers, the ramp has nothing to encode. Use `matrix-grid`, whose cells are tagged at parse time.

When NOT to reach for heatmap.

Precise comparison

Asking a reader which of two similar cells is larger spends the one thing intensity is bad at, and the five-tone binning above makes it stricter: two cells in the same band are the same color by design. If the comparison has to be exact, the value belongs on an axis — `bar` or `line`.

Geography

A value per country or region belongs on the `map` choropleth, which shares this ramp but places the cells where the reader expects them.

RELATED COMPONENTS

See also.

`matrix-grid` — the cells are qualitative — a verb, an owner, a status — rather than a number

`map` — the two dimensions are geographic; same ramp, spatial placement

`bar` — one dimension, and the comparison has to be exact

`quadrant` — two CONTINUOUS axes with items placed on them, rather than two categorical axes with a value at each crossing